

SHUTTLER'S GLORY
Team India pose with their medals and the coveted cup at Impact Arena in Bangkok; (opposite) Lakshya Sen

the 1983 World Cup finals.

"This is an inflection point for Indian badminton," says Gopichand. "The last few years have been very successful, but largely at the individual level. We have depth in the singles and a strong doubles pair capable of beating the best in the world. Moreover, the entire unit worked as a team. This is what has made ours a formidable team that can take on the best of other leading badminton-playing nations."

Over the course of a week at Impact Arena in Bangkok, Team India played with flair and without fear to defeat five-time champions Malaysia and title contenders Denmark. There was no dearth of verve on the court and in the stands, where coaches and support staff gathered to rally behind the players. India the underdogs didn't crumble under pressure, but thrived in it. For instance, H.S. Prannoy won the decisive fifth tie not once but twice, ensuring India got through to the semis and then the finals.

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SMELLS LIKE TEAM SPIRIT

Prannoy had sown the seeds of this win two weeks ago by setting up a WhatsApp group named 'It's coming home', with emojis of a cup, an angry face and the TUC (Thomas & Uber Cup). His first message read: "Buoysssss how's the josh?" The response but naturally was "High sirrrrrrrrr". The nine members in the group were fairly young, including singles player Priyanshu Rajawat, 20; and doubles players Vishnuvardhan Goud Panjala, 21; Dhruv Kapila, 22; Krishna Prasad Garaga, 22; and M.R. Arjun, 25. Prannoy and Srikanth, both 29, became the de facto leaders of the pack. "I appreciated their leadership qualities. They really took care of the younger players," says Vimal Kumar, manager of the Thomas Cup team and coach at the Prakash Padukone Badminton Academy in Bengaluru.

Given that the players compete in individual events during most of the year, Prannoy felt the chat group would help build the camaraderie that would be key to winning the trophy that had eluded India for 73 years. "We didn't have a good history in team events and wanted to change it," said Prannoy. "It is high time the rest of the world feared us. We wanted